

Getting so nervous before an interview you think it's costing you the job

8 findings · 14-step checklist · 1 myth · 9 sources · cheatgrid.com

For anyone whose hands shake or voice wavers before an interview even starts, sure the interviewer can **see straight through it**, and half relieved to have a built-in excuse if it goes badly.

THE GOAL

You're trying to get your answers out clearly while this keyed up, and to stop reading the feeling itself as proof of how you're doing.

CHECKLIST

You're sitting in the waiting area, and the nerves are already ramping up before they call you in.

- ☐ Put your phone away, and stop rereading your notes.
- ☐ Take one slow breath in through your nose and out through your mouth.
- ☐ Spend a minute answering silently: of the things you value, which matters most right now, and why?
- ☐ Picture yourself by name in your head, not as "I," while you wait.
- ☐ Right before you're called in, tell yourself out loud that this is something to look forward to.
- ☐ When they call your name, stand up and walk in at your normal pace.
- ☐ Shake hands, hold their eyes for a moment, and sit down.
- ☐ Keep a glass of water within reach, and take a sip if your mouth goes dry.
- ☐ Once you're seated, keep your hands still and let your voice run at its normal pace.
- ☐ Take one breath before you start your first answer.
- ☐ If you catch yourself worrying about how nervous you seem, redirect to the question in front of you.
- ☐ If the interviewer notices you seem nervous, say so plainly instead of brushing it off: "I am a little nervous, but glad to be here."
- ☐ If your mind goes blank on a question, pause and say, "Let me take a second to think about that."
- ☐ When a question stumps you, name that plainly and say what you'd need to find out.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Raters mark down nervous delivery. They scored the anxious-looking version lower than the calm version for the exact same words, so it's worth steadying your voice and hands anyway.
- 2** Spend a minute on what matters most to you, unrelated to the job, before you go in.
- 3** Staying this nervous can feel like a built-in excuse if it goes badly, but don't let that same urge talk you into stretching an answer: say plainly when you don't know.

What actually shows, and what it doesn't

WATCH

Raters mark down nervous delivery. They scored the anxious-looking version lower than the calm version for the exact same words, so it's worth steadying your voice and hands anyway.

Raters who watched a recording of the same actor delivering identical scripted answers still rated the anxious-looking version as the weaker interview performance. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

You're anchored on your own pulse, so you assume it shows on your face and voice more than it does.

People caught lying, or made to feel disgust in front of others, guessed onlookers could read it far more clearly than outside raters could. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

How anxious you felt walking in has almost no link to how you'll actually do the job once you're hired.

Resident Assistant applicants who reported feeling more anxious in interviews were rated afterward by supervisors and coworkers about the same as everyone else. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Trusting a bad feeling as your verdict can fool you: in a study of surgical-residency candidates, the ones who scored best with real interviewers were hardest on themselves afterward.

So a rough feeling walking out doesn't reliably tell you how you did, whichever way it points. [Source 4](#)

What to do with the feeling, and what not to let it talk you into

SAY

Right before you go in, say "I'm excited about this" out loud instead of trying to talk yourself down to calm.

Saying you're excited nudges you toward seeing the moment as a chance rather than a threat, and that shift is what tends to improve performance. [Source 5](#)

SAY

Talk yourself through it using your own name instead of "I": "Why is [name] so nervous?"

Women who knew judges would rate their first meeting with a male stranger, and prepped this way, were rated calmer and stronger afterward. [Source 6](#)

DO

Spend a minute on what matters most to you, unrelated to the job, before you go in.

College students who affirmed a value that mattered to them before giving an evaluated speech showed a smaller cortisol rise than students who didn't. [Source 7](#)

DON'T

Staying this nervous can feel like a built-in excuse if it goes badly, but don't let that same urge talk you into stretching an answer: say plainly when you don't know.

More interview anxiety was linked to more truth-stretching, which researchers say may be a way of guarding your self-esteem. [Source 8](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you can just get yourself fully calm before you walk in, you'll interview at your best.

ACTUALLY

People who said they were calm before singing karaoke scored lowest, below even those who said they were anxious. **Calm** isn't the goal. Excited is. [Source 9](#)

Sources

1. <https://api.semanticscholar.org/graph/v1/paper/DOI:10.1027/1866-5888/a000319?fields=title,abstract,url>
2. https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/search?query=EXT_ID:9731312&resultType=core&format=json
3. <https://scite.ai/reports/does-interview-anxiety-predict-job-8V1GYja>
4. https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/search?query=EXT_ID:35091273&resultType=core&format=json

5. https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/search?query=EXT_ID:24364682&resultType=core&format=json
6. https://sites.lsa.umich.edu/emotion-selfcontrol-psych/wp-content/uploads/sites/1322/2024/07/KrossJ_Pers_Soc_Psychol2014Self-talk_as_a_regulatory_mechanism_How_you_do_it_matters.pdf
7. https://sites.lifesci.ucla.edu/psych-taylorlab/wp-content/uploads/sites/5/2014/10/2005_Affirmation-of-Personal-Values-Buffers-Neuroendocrine-and-Psych-Stress-Responses.pdf
8. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8550053>
9. <https://www.library.hbs.edu/working-knowledge/overcoming-nervous-nelly>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Interviews at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)